

Branch Protection Rules

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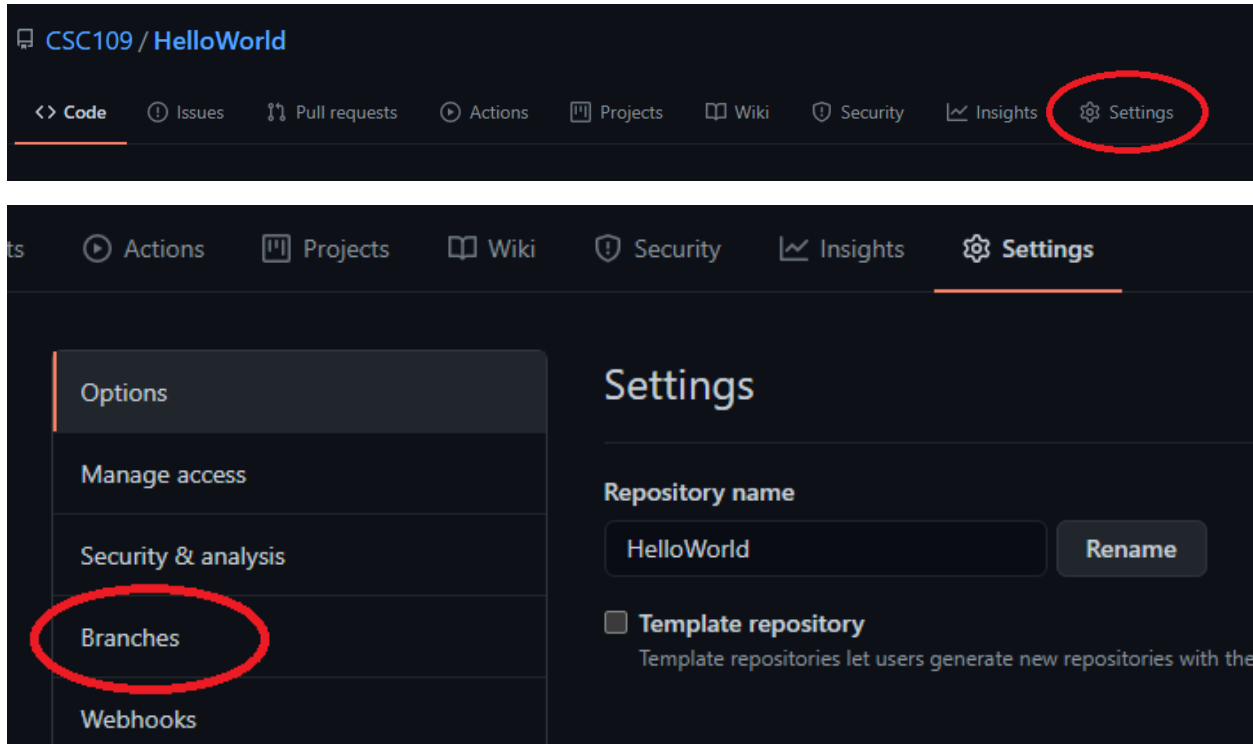
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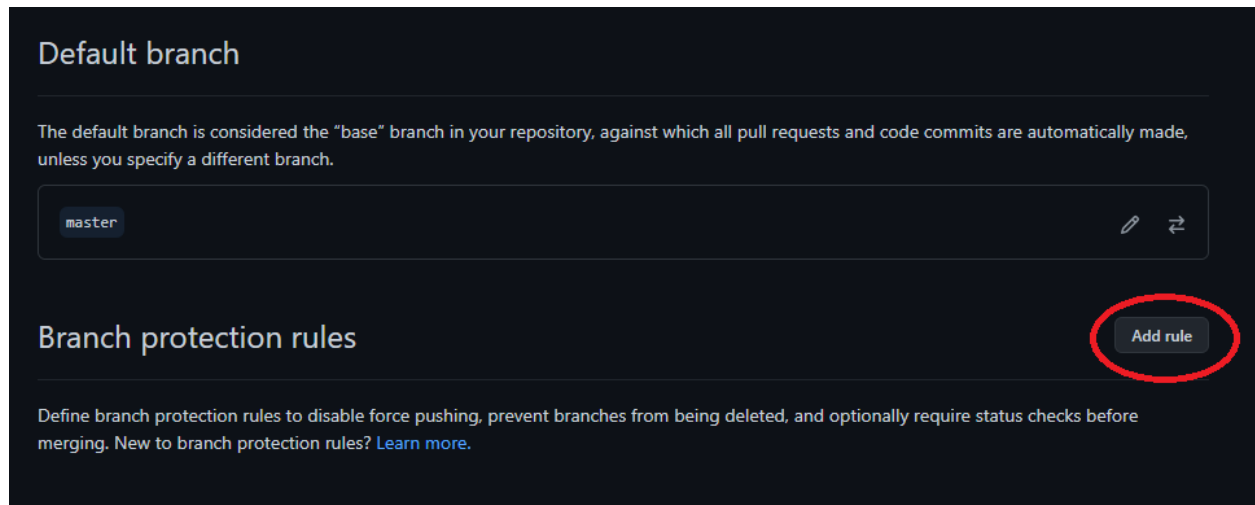
Overview

GitHub allows you to set any branch as **protected**. By marking a branch as protected, it gives repo owners several useful configuration options specifically geared towards keeping a branch safe and secure.

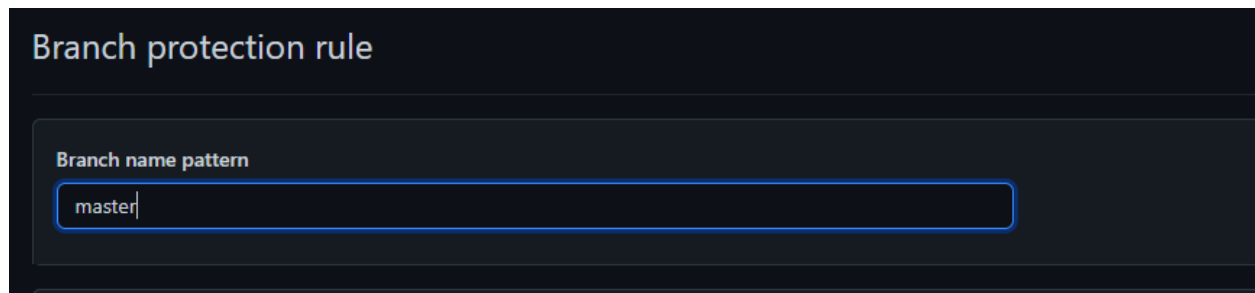
Setup

To get to the branch protection rules area in your repo's settings, go to the **Settings** tab, followed by clicking **Branches** on the left hand navbar. Finally, click the **Add rule** button.

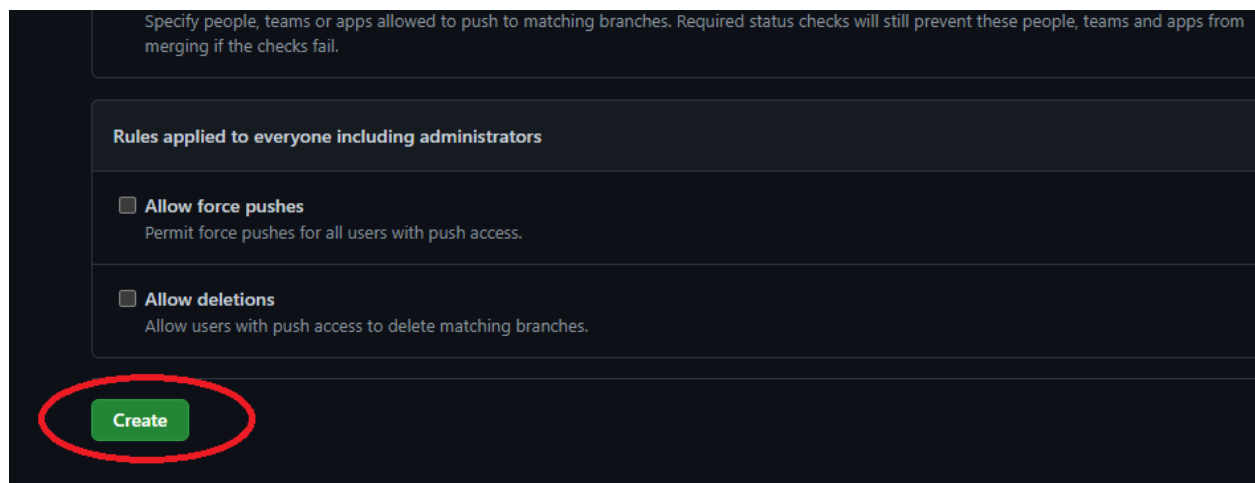




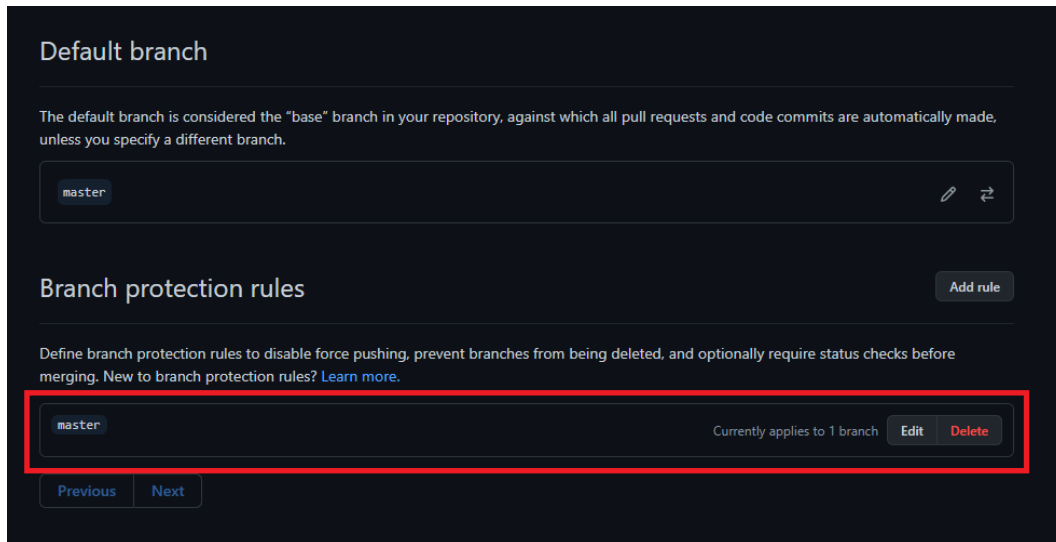
From here, you will type in the name of the protected branch you want your rules to apply to in the **Branch name pattern**. For example, if you wanted this rule to apply to the master branch, you would do:



Then, set the desired rules for the protected branch and hit **Create** at the bottom of the page when finished.



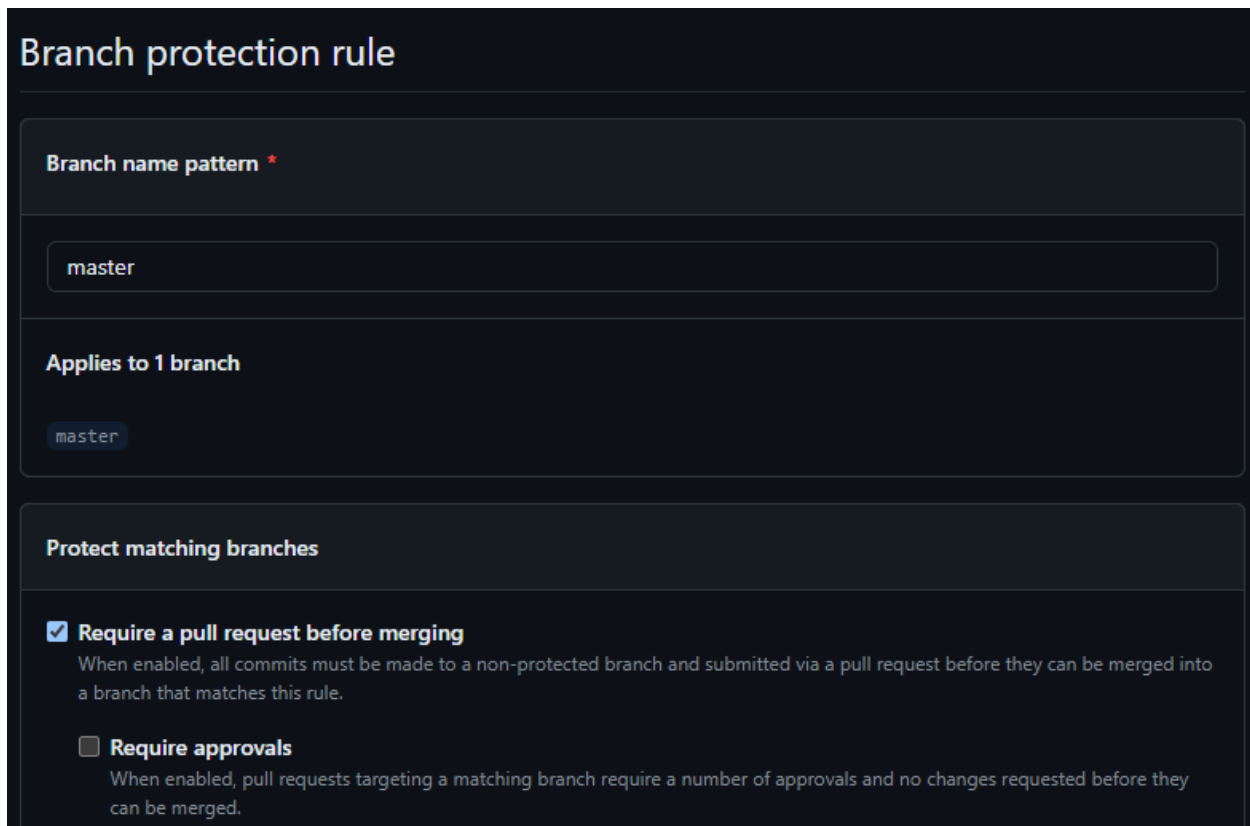
Go back to the **Branches** tab of the **Settings** page to see your rule under the **Branch protection rules** header. At any time, you may edit this rule by clicking the **Edit** button or delete it with the **Delete** button.



Below are some of the most common configuration settings used for protected branches. By default, the master branch is automatically set to protected.

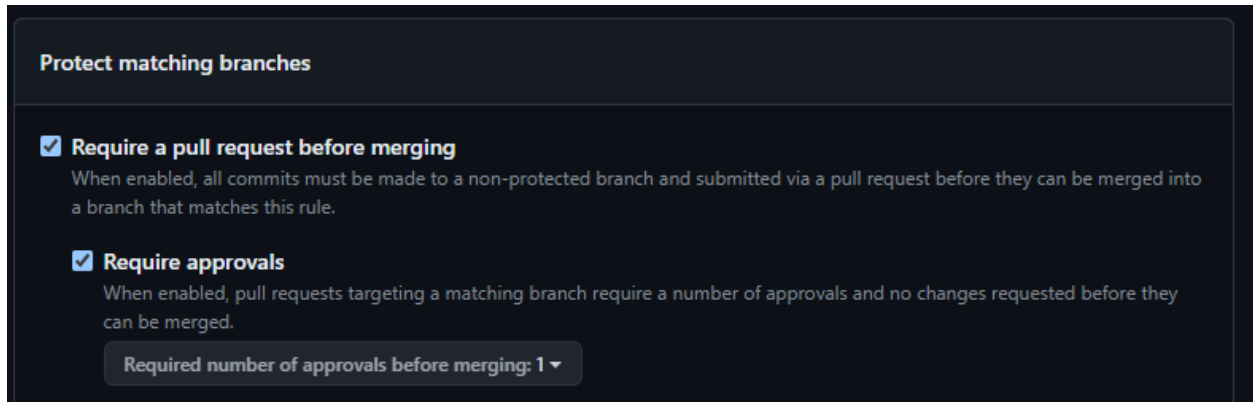
Disallow pushing directly to the master branch

By checking off **Require a pull request before merging**, GitHub will not allow pushes directly to the protected branch. Instead, a branch and pull request will be required to merge anything into a protected branch. This is very commonly used to prevent any developer from pushing directly to the master branch. Even if everyone is disciplined, it just adds additional protection against any slip-ups.



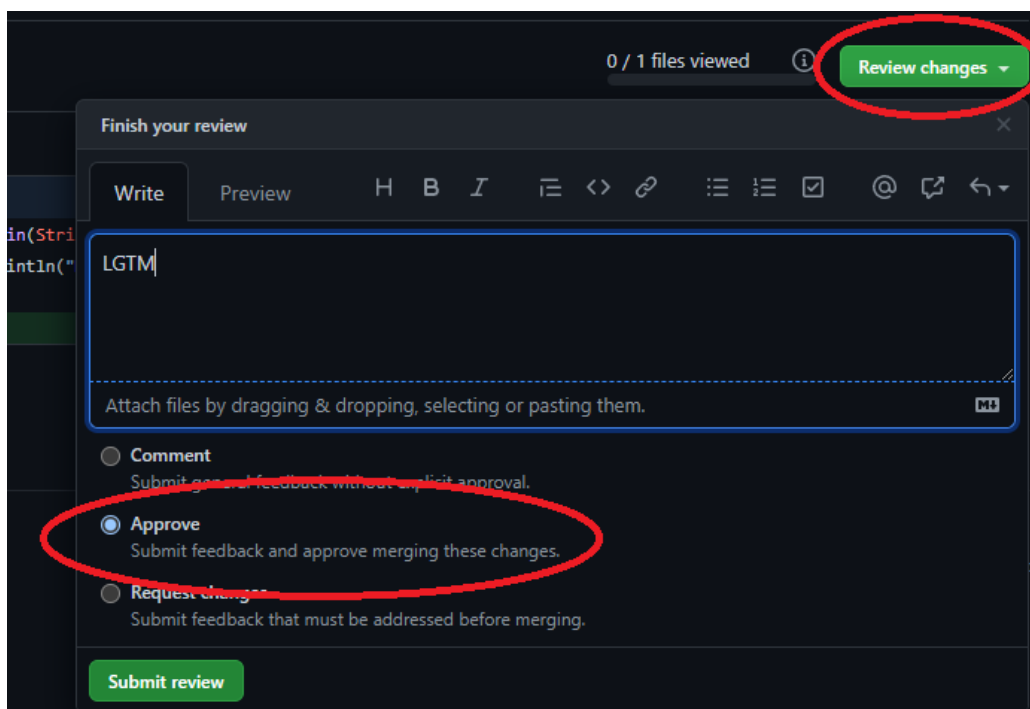
Require pull request approvals before they can be merged

After checking off the **Require a pull request before merging** box from the previous step, additional options will show up, one of which being **Require approvals**. The **Require approvals** option will make it so pull requests have to be explicitly approved by another repo collaborator before they can be merged in. While most developers won't merge in code without it being reviewed by another team member, this setting forces them to.



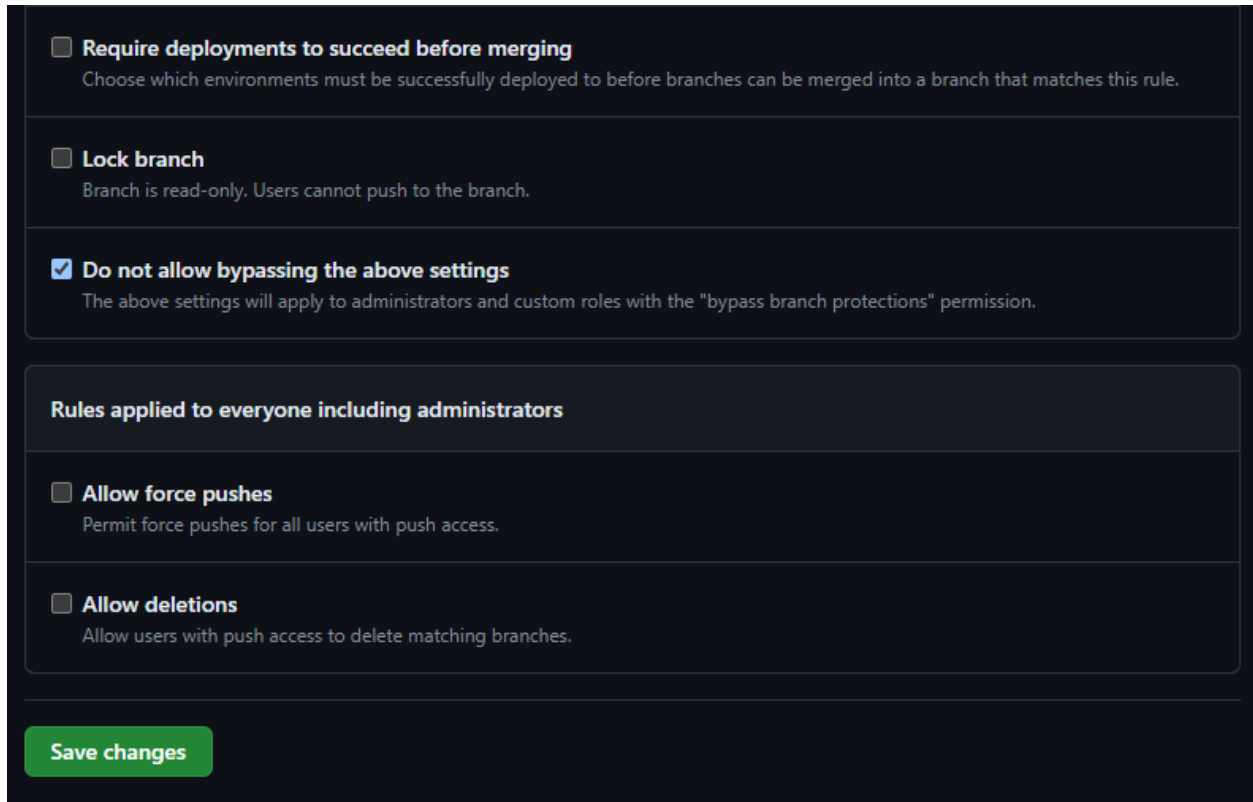
You can change the number of required approving reviews in the dropdown (default is set to 1). Honestly, one approving review should be good enough, but in the workplace, you'll see times where it's set to something like three or four and you will just hate yourself waiting around for it to get looked at.

To approve another developer's pull request (after reviewing it), click on the **Files changed** tab, and you'll see a green button that says **Review changes** on the far right. From there, hit the **Approve** radio button, optionally enter a comment, and then finally **Submit review** to seal it with your approval.



Include administrators

When creating branch protection rules, by default administrators are exempt from having to follow the rules. The owner of the repository is automatically an administrator. To enforce the rules for all owners, check off the **Do not allow bypassing the above settings** option. While some teams are fine with the administrator be able to circumvent the rules if they are highly respected and trusted, it's generally not a good idea to exempt administrators. Everyone has slip-ups!



The screenshot shows the GitHub branch protection settings interface. It features a dark theme with a light gray sidebar on the left. The main content area has a dark background with light gray text. The settings are organized into sections with a light gray header. The first section contains three options: 'Require deployments to succeed before merging' (unchecked), 'Lock branch' (unchecked), and 'Do not allow bypassing the above settings' (checked). The second section, titled 'Rules applied to everyone including administrators', contains two options: 'Allow force pushes' (unchecked) and 'Allow deletions' (unchecked). A green 'Save changes' button is located at the bottom left of the main content area.

- ☐ **Require deployments to succeed before merging**
Choose which environments must be successfully deployed to before branches can be merged into a branch that matches this rule.
- ☐ **Lock branch**
Branch is read-only. Users cannot push to the branch.
- ☒ **Do not allow bypassing the above settings**
The above settings will apply to administrators and custom roles with the "bypass branch protections" permission.

Rules applied to everyone including administrators

- ☐ **Allow force pushes**
Permit force pushes for all users with push access.
- ☐ **Allow deletions**
Allow users with push access to delete matching branches.

[Save changes](#)